Chapter 12

INDIVIDUAL AND SOCIETY

The 'Sociality' of Man: The Central Problem of Sociology — Man Depends on Society — The two Theories Concerning the Nature of Society — The Social Contract Theory — The Organismic Theory — Limitations of the Theories — The Inseparable Individual and the Society — Man in Society and Society in Man — Scope for Individuality.

Man is a social animal. He lives in social groups, in communities and in society. Human life and society almost go together. Man cannot live as man, without society. Solitary life is unbearable to him. Man is biologically and psychologically equipped to live in groups, in society. Society has become an essential condition for human life to arise and to continue. Society is more than our environment. It is within us as well as around us.

There is a vast literature on the questions such as the nature or the essence of man's social life, it's origin and sources. It is essential to study the deepest relations that exist between the individual and society. It is equally significant to know the nature of man's motives or impulses towards society.

The 'Sociality' of Man : The Central Problem of Sociology

It was Aristotle who said long back that man is a social animal. This proposition gives room to the central problem of sociology *i.e.*, the *sociability* or the *sociality* of man. The essential fact is that man always belongs to a society or a group of one kind or the other, and without it, he cannot exist. Several questions of great sociological importance arise in this regard. "In what sense man is a social animal ? In what sense do we belong to society ? In what sense society belongs to us ? What is the nature of our dependence upon it ?" These questions take us to a more fundamental question of the relation between the individual and society.

The relationship between individual and society is ultimately one of the most profound of all the problems of social philosophy. It is, in fact, a philosophical rather than a sociological problem, because it involves the question of values. We see ourselves on one side and our society on the other–the person and the group, the individual and the collectivity. What does each owe to the other? In what sense is the single individual a part of a whole that is greater than he ? In what sense does the whole exist for the individual ? When we accept the statement of Aristotle that man is a social animal, what does this proposition ultimately mean ? These are some of the difficult questions. The sociologist cannot remain silent when confronted with these larger issues of human worth and human destiny.

Man Depends on Society

It is a thing of common observation of every one that the individual is living, breathing, working, playing, resting, praying, enjoying, suffering, sometimes sweating, sometimes swearing with millions like him in society. It is in the society that an individual is surrounded and encompassed by culture, a societal force. It is in the society again, that he has to conform to the norms, occupy statuses and become members of groups. Then, what is the role and responsibility of an individual to himself and to his society ? Is the individual lost in society, or is it only in society, that he can find himself.

It is a self-obvious fact that man has not only a capacity for social life but also an intrinsic need of it. Emotional development, intellectual maturity and a certain amount of material goods and comforts for the full exercise of his liberty and progress are unthinkable without society. No human being is known to have normally developed in isolation. A few instances like that of *Kasper Hauser*; the *wolf-children* of India called Kamala and her sister; the isolated, *illegitimate child Anna* and others have fortified the fact that man develops human qualities only in society. He can attain his real nature only in society. The psychological development of the social consciousness of the child is also a confirmation of the natural sociality of the human being. The biological potentiality of becoming social is inherent in the very social nature of man.

Two Theories Concerning the Nature of Society

The question of the relation between the individual and the society is the starting point of many social investigations. The question of the nature of society is closely connected with the question of the relationship of man and society. There are two main theories regarding the relationships of man and society which have been propounded by several thinkers and writers. They are (*i*) The Social Contract Theory, and (*ii*) The Organismic Theory.

1. SOCIAL CONTRACT THEORY

The '*social contract theory*' throws light on the origin of the society. According to this theory, all men are born free and equal. Individual precedes society. Society came into existence because of an agreement entered into by the individuals. The classical representatives of this school of thought are *Thomas Hobbes, John Locke,* and *J.J. Rousseau*. The three of them thought in various ways that before the existence of civil society men lived in a sort of pre-social state, called *the state of nature*, and in virtue of a contract among themselves, society came into existence. The essence of their argument is as follows:

(*a*) **Thomas Hobbes** (1588-1679). Thomas Hobbes, an English thinker, was of the opinion that society came into being as a means for the protection of men against the consequences of their own nature. Man in the state of nature was in perpetual conflict with his neighbours on account of his essentially selfish nature. To quote Hobbes, the life of man was "*solitary poor, nasty, brutish and short*". Every man was an enemy to every other man.

Hobbes in his book "*Leviathan*" has made it clear that man in the state of nature was not at all social. According to him, man found "*nothing but grief in the company of his fellows*"–all being almost equally "*selfish, self-seeking, cunning, egoistic, brutal and aggressive*". Thus, men in the state of nature were like hungry wolves each ready to pounce on the other with all its ferocity.

Since the conditions in the state of nature were intolerable and men longed for peace, the people entered into a kind of social contract to ensure for themselves security and certainty of life and property. By mutual agreement they decided to surrender their natural rights into the hands of a few or one with authority to command. The covenant or agreement was of each with all and of all with each. The covenant was, of course, a social contract and a governmental contract. The contract became binding on the whole community as a perpetual social bond. Thus, in order to protect himself against the evil consequences of his own nature man organised himself in society in order to live in peace with all.

(*b*) John Locke (1632-1704). John Locke, another English political philosopher, believed that man in the state of nature was enjoying an ideal liberty, free from all sorts of rules and regulations. The state of nature was a state of "*peace, goodwill, mutual assistance, and preservation*". But there was no recognised system of law and justice. Hence his peaceful life was often upset by the "*corruption and viciousness of degenerate men*". Man was forced to face such an "*ill condition*".

John Locke, the British writer who supported the cause of limited monarchy in England, maintained in his "*On Civil Government*" that the "*ill condition*" in which men were forced to live was "*full of fears and continual dangers*". In order to escape from this and to gain certainty and security men made a contract to enter into civil society or the state. This contract Locke called 'social contract'. This contract put an end to the state of nature and substituted it by civil society. The social contract was no more than a surrender of certain rights and powers so that man's remaining rights would be protected and preserved. The contract was for limited and specific purposes, and what was given up or surrendered to the whole community and not to a man or to an assembly of men (as Hobbes said). Locke made it clear that the social contract later on contributed to the governmental control. The governmental contract was made by the society when it established a government and selected a ruler to remove the inconveniences of "ill-condition".

(*c*) Jean Jacques Rousseau (1712-1778). J.J. Rousseau, the French writer of the 18th century, in his famous book "*The Social Contract*" (1762) wrote that man in the state of nature was a '*noble savage*' who led a life of "*primitive simplicity and idyllic happiness*". He was independent, contented, self-sufficient, healthy, fearless and good. It was only primitive instinct and sympathy which united him with others. He knew neither right nor wrong and was free from all notions of virtue and vice. Man enjoyed a pure, unsophisticated, innocent life of perfect freedom and equality in the state of nature, Rousseau argued. Men were free from the influence of civilisation, and sought their own happiness uncontrolled by social laws and social institutions.

But these conditions did not last long. Population increased and reason was dawned. Simplicity and idyllic happiness disappeared. Families were established, institution of property emerged and human equality was ended. Man began to think in terms of '*mine*' and '*thine*'. Difference between stronger and weaker, rich and poor, arose.

Emergence of Civil Society. When equality and happiness of the early state was lost, war, murder, conflicts, wretchedness, etc., became the order of the day. The escape from this was found in the formation of a civil society. Natural freedom gave place to civil freedom by a social contract. As a result of this contract a multitude of individuals became a collective unity—a civil society. Rousseau said that by virtue of this contract "*everyone while uniting himself to all, remains as free as before*".

General Will. There was only one contract according to Rousseau which was social as well as political. The individual surrendered himself completely and unconditionally to the will of the body of which he became a member. The body so created was a moral and collective body and Rousseau called it the '*general will*'. The unique feature of the general will was that it represented collective good as distinguished from the private interests of its members. The will was 'inalienable and indivisible' according to him.

Criticism. The theory of social contract has been widely criticised. (1) Historically, the theory seems to be a mere fiction. There is nothing in the whole range of history to show that the society has ever been deliberately created as a result of voluntary agreement or contract. Nor can we suppose that man could ever think of entering into a contract with others when he lived under conditions of extreme simplicity, ignorance and even brutality.

Secondly, the theory is far away from the facts. Nothing like the state of nature has ever existed. The most primitive peoples that the anthropologists have described lived in some form of society or the other, however rudimentary or unorganised it may be. It is quite unhistorical to suppose, that such men would resort to a contract.

Thirdly, the advocates of the theory hold that the early individuals entered into the contract for their individual safety and security of property. But history tells us the other way. Early law was more communal than individual, and the unit of society was not the individual but the family. Each man was born into his family, and into his status in society. "Society has moved from status to contract and not from contract to status" as the champions of the theory argued. Contract is not the beginning of society but the end of it, said Sir Henry Maine.

Fourthly, our own common sense tells us that there are always two parties to the contract. There cannot be a one-sided contract, as was conceived by Hobbes (Moreover, every contract lapses after the death of one of the contracting parties).

Fifthly, conception of natural rights and natural liberty, as is said to have existed in the state of nature, is illogical and fallacious. Liberty cannot exist in the state of nature. Law is the condition of liberty. Without restraint liberty is nothing short of licence, and condition of licence is anarchy. Rights, too, arise only in a society. If there is no society we cannot think of rights.

Finally, there can be no rights without a consciousness of common interest on the part of members of a society and common consciousness was conspicuous by its absence in the state of nature.

2. THE ORGANISMIC THEORY OF SOCIETY

This view, at least as ancient as the contract idea, conceives society as a biological system, a greater organism, alike in its structure and its functions. This theory can even be dated back to *Plato* and *Aristotle*.

Plato compared society and state to a magnified human being. He divided society into three classes of *rulers*, the *warriors* and *artisans* based upon the three faculties of the human soul, that is wisdom, courage and desire. *Aristotle* drew a comparison between the symmetry of the state and symmetry of the body and firmly held that the individual is an intrinsic part of society.

The parallelism between an individual organism and social organism has been worked out to the minutest possible extent by *Bluntschli* and *Herbert Spencer* during the recent times.

The organic theory considers society as a unity similar to that which characterises a biological organism. The union of individuals forming the society has been described as similar to the union between the several parts of an animal body, wherein all parts are functionally related. Just as the body has a natural unity, so has a social group. The animal body is composed of cells, so is the society composed of individuals, and as is the "*relation of the hand to the body or the leaf to the tree, so is the relation of man to society. He exists in it and it in him*".

The ancient and medieval writers had merely drawn an analogy between the society and an organism. They held that the society resembled an organism. But the writers of the 19th century regarded the society as an organism. They tried to analyse the structure and function of society in comparison with those of an organism.

Views of Herbert Spencer

The English social philosopher Herbert Spencer has been the chief exponent of this theory. He said that society is an organism and it does not differ in essential principle from the other biological organisms. The attributes of an organism and the society, he maintained, are similar. Both exhibit the same process of development. The animal and social bodies, Spencer affirmed, begin as germs, all similar and simple in structure. As they grow and develop, they become unlike and complex in structure. Their process of development is the same, both moving from similarity and simplicity to dissimilarity and complexity. "*As the lowest type of animal is all stomach, respiratory surface, or limb, so primitive society is all warrior, all hunter, all builder, or all tool-maker. As society grows in complexity, division of labour follows...*"

In each case there is mutual dependence of parts. Just as the hand depends on the arm and the arm on the body and head, so do the parts of social organism depend on each other. Every organism depends for its life and full performance of its functions on the proper co-ordination and interrelation of the units. As the diseased condition of one organ affects the health and proper functioning of other organs, similarly, individuals who form society are inseparably connected with one another for the realisation of their best self. There is so much dependence of one on the other that the distress of one paralyses the rest of the society. The society and organism, it is pointed out are subject to wear and tear and then replacement. (Just as cell tissues and blood corpuscles in the animal organism, wear out and are replaced by new ones, in the same manner, old, infirm, and diseased persons die giving place to newly born persons).

Spencer gives striking structural analogies between society and organism. He says, society, too, has three systems corresponding to the (1) *sustaining system*, (2) *the distributary system*, and (3) *the regulating system in an organism*.

(1) *The sustaining system* in an organism consists of mouth, gullet, stomach and intestines. It is by means of this system that food is digested and the whole organic machine is sustained. Society has its own sustaining system which refers to the productive system comprising the manufacturing districts and agricultural areas. The workers, *i.e.*, the men who farm the soil, work the mines and factories and workshops are the alimentary organs of a society.

(2) *The distributary system* in an organism consists of the blood vessels, heart, arteries and veins and they carry blood to all parts of the body. Means of communication and transport and along with them the wholesalers, retailers, bankers, railway and steamshipmen and others may correspond to the distributary or vascular system of an organism. Society's Cells are individuals only. And what the arteries and veins mean to the human body, roads, railways, post and telegraph services, institutions and associations, mean to society.

(3) Finally, *the regulating system* is the nerve-motor mechanism which regulates the whole body. Government in society, regulates and controls the activities of the individuals. The professional men–doctors, lawyers, engineers, rulers, priests, the thinkers, in short, perform the functions of the brain and the nervous system. Further, as Spencer opined society also passes through the organic processes of birth, youth, maturity, old age and death.

Murray sums up the points of resemblance between a society and an individual organism as noted by Spencer in the following ways :-

(*i*) Society as well as individual organism grow in size.

(*ii*) They grow from comparatively a simple structure to that of an increasingly complex one.

(*iii*) Increasing differentiation leads to increasing mutual dependence of the component parts. The life and normal functioning of each becomes dependent on the life of the whole.

(*iv*) The life of the whole becomes independent and lasts longer than the life of the component parts.

Spencer hence argued that society is a social organism. Individuals are the limbs of the society and behave as cells of the body whose activity and life are meant for the sake of the whole. Limbs separated from body have no life, and similarly individuals separated from society have no life. The individuals exist in and within society.

Criticism

(*i*) The analogy used in the organic theory has, no doubt, a useful purpose to serve as it stresses the unity of society. The society is not a mere aggregation of individuals. It is a social

unity. Man cannot lead a life of isolation. Dependence is his very psychology, and individuals depend on one another and on society as a whole. The welfare of each is involved in the welfare of all. Every individual has obligations to himself, to his family, to his neighbours, and to the society of which he is a unit. He cannot be separated from society, just as a hand or a leg, without losing its utility cannot be separated from the body.

(*ii*) The analogy used here to compare society with an organism, has its own limitations. Even Spencer was aware of these. He himself noted some of the defects of this analogy such as the following

*A society has no specific form comparable to the body of an individual;

*The units of a society, *i.e.*, individuals are not fixed in their respective positions like those of an individual organism;

*The units of a society are dispersed persons and are not physically continuous like cells of the individual;

*Society has no 'common sensorium', no central organ of perception and thought as an individual has.

(*iii*) The proposition that society is like an organism is acceptable with some reservations. But the assertion that society is an organism is rather misleading